Haligric Research Integration Series

Children of Ussen and White Painted Woman

A COMPLETE DEEP DIVE

The Sacred Traditions of the Western Apache, Chiricahua, Mescalero, Jicarilla, and Lipan Peoples

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In the mountains and deserts of the American Southwest, the Apache peoples built a ceremonial world centered on a single, unrepeatable moment: the four days when a girl becomes a woman and, for those four days, becomes White Painted Woman herself.

Masked dancers embodying the mountain spirits circle her by firelight. A supreme, largely unnamed god called Ussen watches from beyond the visible world. And on a stretch of high desert called Oak Flat, ceremonies have been held since long before anyone kept count.

This is the world of Lozen, who could point to where the enemy hid, and of Cochise and Geronimo, whose resistance became the last serious armed defense of Indigenous land in the United States.

It is also, this year, the site of one of the country's most consequential ongoing religious-freedom fights.

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Introduction — Children of Ussen and White Painted Woman

The Apache peoples — commonly grouped as the Western Apache (including the San Carlos and White Mountain bands), Chiricahua, Mescalero, Jicarilla, and Lipan, along with the linguistically related but administratively distinct Navajo — are Southern Athabaskan-speaking nations whose ancestors migrated into the American Southwest from the north, arriving in the region several centuries before sustained European contact.

Apache religious life centers on Ussen (also spelled Yusn), a largely transcendent supreme deity credited with creating the world and, crucially, with the birth of White Painted Woman (also called Changing Woman), the Apache people's founding mother figure whose story anchors both cosmology and the single most important Apache ceremony still practiced today: the girls' puberty rite known in Western Apache as Na'ii'ees, or the Sunrise Ceremony.

Origins and Cosmology

Apache creation tradition describes Ussen shaping the world and its first beings, the Hactcin — powerful, benevolent spirits who in turn helped create and instruct the first humans and animals before withdrawing from direct contact with the world. White Painted Woman, born of this early sacred order, is remembered as having given birth to a hero-son (in various tellings, Child of the Water or Killer of Enemies) who defeated monsters threatening the Apache people, in a mythic cycle structurally similar to hero narratives found among the related Navajo.

White Painted Woman is understood not as a distant historical figure but as an ever-renewing presence: each time a Western Apache girl undergoes her Sunrise Ceremony, she is understood to actually become White Painted Woman for the four days of the rite, channeling the founding mother's power directly into the community rather than merely commemorating her.

The Sunrise Ceremony — Na'ii'ees, Step by Step

The Sunrise Ceremony is a four-day rite of passage marking a Western Apache or Mescalero girl's transition to womanhood, requiring roughly a year of advance preparation, including the gathering of cottonwood poles, yucca, and other ceremonial materials, and the making of the buckskin camp dress the girl will wear throughout. During the ceremony itself, she is never referred to by her own name but only as White Painted Woman, and is guided throughout by a medicine man who directs the ceremony's songs and prayers, alongside a female sponsor — typically a woman who has already undergone her own Sunrise Ceremony — who assists with the girl's physical needs, since for the four days she may not touch water directly (drinking instead through a hollow reed), scratch or touch her own skin, or arrange her own hair or clothing.

The rite is built around sustained physical endurance understood as spiritual demonstration: the girl dances for hours across the four days, at points dancing on her knees with her arms raised skyward, while relatives contribute dozens of traditional songs sung across the ceremony. On the final night, Gaan dancers — the masked Mountain Spirit dancers described below — lead the concluding rites, and the girl is painted with white clay drawn from the surrounding mountains, a symbolic act of protection against aging and misfortune understood to seal the transformation and blessing she has received.

The ceremony functions simultaneously as religious rite, community celebration, and formal social recognition: it publicly marks the young woman's new adult status, and the message or blessing she receives from her godmother during the rite is understood to remain a source of guidance for the rest of her life.

The Crown Dance and the Mountain Spirits

The Apache Crown Dance, known also as the Gaan Dance or Mountain Spirit Dance, features dancers who embody the Gaan, powerful mountain-dwelling spirits, through elaborate wooden crown headdresses, black hoods, and body paint, along with wands carried in each hand; a performance traditionally involves a group of dancers together with a distinct clown figure whose separate ritual role includes carrying a mixture of ochre and corn pollen that is brushed or sprinkled over participants as a blessing and spiritual cleansing.

Understood as a genuine embodiment of spiritual power rather than theatrical representation, the Crown Dance serves an explicitly protective and healing function for the whole community — guarding against disease and misfortune — and reaches its highest ceremonial importance on the final night of the Sunrise Ceremony, when the Gaan dancers lead the girl through the concluding rites of her transformation into womanhood. Each Apache community maintains its own specific traditions regarding the Gaan's history and meaning, knowledge traditionally passed to younger generations during winter gatherings.

Key Figures Who Shaped Apache History

Cochise, principal leader of the Chiricahua Apache in the mid-nineteenth century, led sustained resistance to U.S. and Mexican encroachment following the breakdown of an earlier peace, becoming one of the most militarily effective Indigenous leaders of the era before eventually negotiating a reservation settlement shortly before his death.

Victorio, chief of the Chihenne Chiricahua band, led a defensive campaign (Victorio's War, 1879-1881) against forced relocation to the San Carlos reservation, in which his sister Lozen — a warrior and spiritual figure recognized by Victorio himself as 'my right hand,' strong and cunning in strategy — played a central military and ceremonial role, most famously leading women and children across a dangerously flooded Rio Grande and reportedly using a prophetic ritual, standing with arms outstretched and turning while chanting to Ussen, to detect the direction and distance of approaching enemy forces.

Geronimo, the best-known Chiricahua leader of the era, led the last major armed Apache resistance to U.S. and Mexican forces through the 1880s, surrendering in 1886 in what is generally regarded as the last significant organized Indigenous military resistance in the United States; Lozen was among those who surrendered with him, later dying in captivity at Mount Vernon Barracks, Alabama, in 1889.

Self-Care, Wellness, and Daily Practice

Traditional Apache healing understands illness as a disruption of balance among mind, body, and spirit rather than a purely physical event, and treatment historically and still today often combines herbal medicine, prayer, and ceremony administered by trained medicine people whose authority rests on both practical knowledge and spiritual standing within the community.

The cradleboard, used across Apache communities to carry infants, carries ceremonial as well as practical significance, with specific blessing rites performed at a baby's first placement in the cradleboard; sweat lodge purification, prayer, and traditional song remain in active use both for physical ailments and for restoring spiritual and emotional balance, frequently integrated today alongside conventional healthcare through tribal health programs that explicitly recognize ceremony as a legitimate component of care rather than a supplement to it.

Because the Sunrise Ceremony's physical demands are understood as inseparable from its spiritual purpose, sustained physical endurance itself functions as a wellness practice within Apache tradition: the belief that spiritual strength and bodily discipline reinforce one another runs through Apache ceremonial life well beyond the puberty rite itself.

Sacred Landscape — Oak Flat and Ceremonial Geography

Oak Flat, known in Apache as Chi'chil Biłdagoteel, is a high-desert site in central Arizona that has been used for sacred Western Apache ceremonies, by tribal accounts, since time immemorial, including rites connected to the same Gaan/Mountain Spirit tradition described above; it is formally recognized on the National Register of Historic Places as a Western Apache Traditional Cultural Property and National Historic District. Specific ceremonies are described by Apache practitioners as unable to be relocated or reproduced at another site, since their sacred efficacy is tied to the specific landscape itself rather than being transferable ritual technology.

This understanding — that particular ceremonies belong irreducibly to particular ground — is a recurring feature of Apache and broader Southwestern Indigenous religious thought, and is the central point of contention in the land dispute described in the closing section below.

Legacy and Influence

The Sunrise Ceremony remains one of the most intact and actively practiced Indigenous coming-of-age rites in North America, continuing to be held regularly among the Western Apache and Mescalero communities and drawing documented interest and coverage from national media as a living, rather than historical, tradition.

Lozen's story has become an increasingly prominent touchstone in broader recognition of Indigenous women's military and spiritual leadership, cited in historical scholarship and popular accounts alongside her brother Victorio and alongside Geronimo, with whom she fought until the final surrender in 1886.

Apache resistance history — through Cochise, Victorio, and Geronimo — is frequently cited as marking the effective end of large-scale organized Indigenous armed resistance in the continental United States, giving the Apache nations an outsized place in the broader American historical narrative of Indigenous-settler conflict relative to their population.

Oak Flat and Religious Freedom — Controversies and Fairness

Since 2014, when a rider attached to a federal defense appropriations bill authorized transferring Oak Flat to Resolution Copper — a mining venture majority-owned by the multinational Rio Tinto, itself substantially Chinese-invested — for a proposed copper mine that would, according to the company's own plans, ultimately collapse the site into a crater roughly two miles wide and 1,100 feet deep, the advocacy group Apache Stronghold has fought the transfer through the courts, arguing it violates Apache religious freedom under federal law.

The Ninth Circuit Court of Appeals ruled in 2024 that the land transfer was not subject to federal religious-freedom protections, and on May 27, 2025, the U.S. Supreme Court declined to hear Apache Stronghold's appeal, clearing the final legal obstacle to the transfer; Justice Neil Gorsuch dissented from the denial, calling it 'a grave mistake.' The land transfer proceeded on schedule in mid-2025, though Apache Stronghold has stated its intention to continue pursuing legal and public advocacy against the mine's development. Resolution Copper and its supporters frame the project as critical to domestic copper supply for energy infrastructure and national defense; Apache Stronghold and allied religious-freedom organizations frame it as the deliberate destruction of an active, irreplaceable sacred site — a dispute that remains unresolved in practice even after the legal proceedings concluded.

Closing

The Sunrise Ceremony is still danced today, in Arizona and New Mexico, exactly as demanding and exactly as sacred as it was for Lozen's generation.

Oak Flat, where some of these same rites and their antecedents have been held for centuries, is now, as of 2025, legally cleared for transfer to a foreign-backed mining company over the Apache Stronghold's continued objection — a loss the tribes involved say cannot be measured in the land alone.

Grand rising to the children of Ussen and White Painted Woman — this account continues as their fight for Oak Flat does.